situation worsened, turning violent during August and September. After talks with military commanders Maung Maung and Aung Gyi, Nu made the decision to hand over the reigns to the military so that a caretaker government could be temporarily formed under the leadership of General Ne Win.

U Nu encouraged the population to put their faith in Ne Win, who promised that free elections would be held within six months. The rationale behind this decision was based on the belief that stability and order would be restored with the general in charge. This would supposedly make the democratic transition easier to accomplish.

THE CARETAKER PERIOD: 1958–1960

The primary task of the caretaker government was to restore law and order to Myanmar, no matter what the consequences were to the freedoms and liberties of the population. Hundreds of arrests were made and numerous rebel groups were beaten into submission. Ne Win also oversaw a bureaucratic reorganization in towns and villages. Civilian politicians and party politicians were removed from positions of power and replaced by civil servants and individuals with connections to the armed forces. Interestingly enough, the army was not directly involved in politics, but their role was to be administrative in nature. The reality was that the military entered government buildings and police stations, set up roadblocks throughout the cities, and checked for hidden weapons caches.

Many Burmese citizens believed that a coup had taken place. A number of weeks passed before the situation was clear to most people. U Nu claimed that power was transferred to avoid bloodshed and possible foreign intervention. Student groups and other organizations fearful of military suppression staged protests against the change.

The new Burmese administration pushed for a dramatic overhaul of the administration. Bureaucracy mismanagement and endemic corruption plagued Burmese politics. The essential key to changing the system was to get input from the population; clear communication challenges were vital. The National Solidarity Associations (NSA) were formed throughout the country, with the goal of creating democracy on a grassroots level. This in turn would build confidence in the system, leading to economic growth.